RAPHAEL MERCHANT

SENIOR CORPORATE PHOTOGRAPHER · EVENT & EDITORIAL PHOTOGRAPHY

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Senior corporate photographer specialising in corporate events, live-action capture and studio portrait work, delivering high-volume photography on daily deadlines with fast-turnaround editing and delivery. At CoStar Group, as Regional Visual Media Lead / Field Research Photographer, I managed all visual media deliverables for every CoStar subsidiary across the Greater Golden Horseshoe, CoStar's largest region in Canada — 14,600+ listings across corporate, retail and residential environments, working client-facing with property managers, brokers, developers and homeowners, and operating as a one-person production unit owning camera, drone and virtual-tour capture, equipment readiness and production logistics, with asset and metadata workflows feeding CoStar's in-house research teams and database; part of the team that launched Apartments.com in Canada. At Studio Nostalgia, as Studio Lead, I ran studio and portrait photography at volume and trained and mentored seasonal photographers in teams of up to 15. Under AKASM, my independent creative practice, I shoot brand, commercial and event photography for national clients including Starbucks, Chipotle, Best Buy, Roots, Uber Eats and DoorDash. Transport Canada Advanced RPAS pilot, 1,687 flights. BFA, York University. Based in Mississauga.

PROFESSIONAL EXPERIENCE

Director | Photographer | Filmmaker

akasm, Independent Creative Studio

01/2018–Present

Independent creative practice — freelance and contract work alongside full-time roles from 2018 to 2025; full-time practice since 2025.

- Art-direct and produce brand campaigns and content systems for national clients, covering photo, film and social, from first concept through final delivery and approval.
- Build shoots end to end: casting, locations, crew and vendor sourcing, schedules and shot lists, then direct on set and own post-production through QC and delivery.
- Design campaign looks and visual systems that hold across retail, digital and experiential environments; present concepts and finished work directly to client stakeholders and own revisions through sign-off.
- Own production budgets line by line, forecasting spend and reconciling actuals, with full financial accountability to clients on every engagement.
- Operate as lead photographer and director on set for stills, motion and aerial, with a Transport Canada Advanced RPAS certificate behind the aerial work.
- Early adopter of AI-assisted production: Higgsfield and the generative tools inside Adobe Creative Cloud, integrated into campaign workflows where they raise the craft bar.
- Recognition woven through the practice: staged food photography honoured at TopPhotoAwards (2021); named among Toronto's Best Photographers by Snappr (2019).

Production & Operations Lead

Bricks, Mississauga

01/2025–Present

- Bricks is a Canadian real-estate media and operations platform, book → pay → auto-assign → shoot → delivered.
- Runs the business alone as sole operator, owning every pricing, margin, resourcing and revenue decision, with full P&L accountability.

Regional Visual Media Lead / Field Research Photographer

CoStar Group, Greater Golden Horseshoe

06/2023–06/2025

- Managed all visual media deliverables for every CoStar subsidiary across the Greater Golden Horseshoe, CoStar's largest region in Canada, covering photography, drone and virtual tours, owning the quality, consistency and delivery of property media at regional scale.
- Part of the team that launched Apartments.com in Canada, owning the visual deliverables behind the launch; that media went on to feed national Apartments.com campaigns, including Super Bowl commercial productions.
- Set and held the visual standard for property media across 14,600+ listings, including interiors, exteriors, aerials and virtual tours shot in live retail and residential environments.
- Flew 1,687 drone missions (1,580 km, 157 hours) under a Transport Canada Advanced RPAS certificate, delivering aerial coverage to enterprise QC standards.
- Served as the client-facing front line of the CoStar brand in the field, communicating with property managers, brokers, developers and homeowners on site.
- Operated as a one-person production unit, handling camera, gimbal, drone and virtual-tour capture, and maintaining company equipment to CoStar safety standards.
- Fed field intelligence, including new listings, construction status and tenant changes, back to CoStar's in-house research teams, closing the loop between capture and database.

Selected credits: Apartments.com Canada launch team · media contributed to national Apartments.com campaigns, including Super Bowl commercial productions

Studio Lead

Studio Nostalgia
01/2020–01/2023

- Led the studio's creative output across seasonal and graduation programmes, covering session planning, shoot direction, post-production and delivery.
- Trained and mentored seasonal photographers, in teams of up to 15 at peak, on craft, shoot workflows and client service.
- Built the shoot systems, staffing plans and quality bar the studio ran on through peak season, with scheduling and coverage planned around seasonal demand spikes.
- Held image-quality and client-experience standards across high-volume studio days; reviewed delivered work and coached photographers up to the standard.
- Ran studio operations day to day: session flow, equipment readiness and a consistent client experience from booking to delivery.

Credit Supervisor

Royal Bank of Canada
01/2018–01/2020

- Caught a $50,000-vs-$5,000 keying error in case review before it posted, the kind of miss that becomes a client loss and a compliance incident.
- Supervised live client account and credit casework in a high-volume, full-time call centre, assigning, reviewing and verifying agent work for accuracy against bank compliance standards, including approving credit increases beyond the system's predetermined limit where the situation warranted, including temporary increases.
- Resolved escalated client cases under regulatory pressure, coordinating with other departments and de-escalating distressed clients through to resolution.

General Banking Specialist

Bank of Montreal
01/2016–01/2018

- Front-line client service in a high-volume, full-time banking call centre: everyday account inquiries, servicing and maintenance resolved at first point of contact.
- Navigated multiple banking systems simultaneously while handling live accounts, holding accuracy and compliance routines on every call.
- De-escalated frustrated clients and educated them on digital banking channels, protecting both the client relationship and the bank's risk position.

Administrative Assistant / Receptionist

Royal LePage Signature, Mississauga
01/2014–01/2015

- Supported deal administration end to end, including document handling, deadline tracking and communication between agents, clients and legal offices.
- Front-of-house at a high-volume real-estate brokerage: first point of contact for clients, agents and walk-ins, handling phones, reception and office flow.
- Coordinated appointments, showings and agent calendars; prepared listing paperwork and maintained listing and client files.

SELECTED CLIENTS

Real commissions: Starbucks · Chipotle · Storage Mart · Best Buy · LoveCorn · Roots · Uber Eats · DoorDash

Spec / concept work: Land Rover

CORE COMPETENCIES

Photography: Real Estate, Commercial & Brand Photography · Interiors, Exteriors & Aerials · Portrait & Studio Photography · On-Location Capture

Production: End-to-End Shoot Production · Shot Lists, Scheduling & Client Service On Site · Post-Production & Delivery · Quality Standards

Video & Aerial: Cinematic Video & Virtual Tours · Gimbal & Drone Operation · Transport Canada Advanced RPAS Pilot Certificate · 1,687 Flights

TOOLS

Capture One · Adobe Creative Suite (Lightroom, Photoshop, Premiere Pro, After Effects, Illustrator, InDesign) · Final Cut Pro · Figma · Higgsfield · Frame.io · Notion · Asana · Monday.com · Airtable

RECOGNITION & CERTIFICATION

TopPhotoAwards 2021 · Snappr 2019 · Transport Canada Advanced RPAS (Drone) Pilot Certificate, 1,687 flights / 1,580 km / 157 hours

EDUCATION

Bachelor of Fine Arts (BFA), York University, 2014–2018